

BRONTË SISTERS

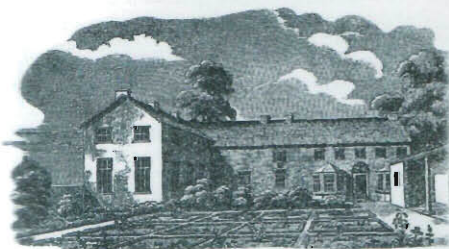


THREE OF THE FINEST writers of the 19th century, Charlotte, Anne, and Emily Brontë, were brought up in solitude in a small town in northern

England. In spite of many difficulties, including being far away from the world of publishing in London, they produced some of the most popular novels of the period. The books portrayed characters with a new frankness and showed how difficult life could be for women of that era. Their stories still enthral readers of today.

Education

Charlotte and Emily were sent away to Cowan Bridge school. The conditions were poor and made Charlotte ill. Lowood school, in *Jane Eyre*, is based on her time there. All three sisters later worked as teachers, or governesses – one of the few jobs then open to educated young women.



Cowan Bridge school

Manuscripts are still preserved at Haworth parsonage.



Poetry manuscript by Charlotte Brontë at around the age of 14

Brontë family

Charlotte, Emily, and Anne lived with their father, Patrick Brontë and their brother, Branwell. Their mother, Maria, died when the children were young and two other children died in infancy, so the sisters were brought up by their aunt. They had a lonely life. They mixed little with other children and had to make their own entertainment.

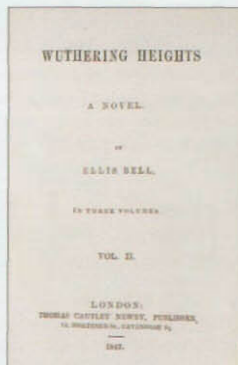


Novelists

In 1846, the Brontës started to get their works published. They began with a volume of poems, but only two copies were sold. In the following two years Emily's *Wuthering Heights*, Charlotte's *Jane Eyre*, and Anne's *Agnes Grey* were published. At the time it was not thought proper for the daughters of clergymen to write fiction, so the sisters used pseudonyms (false names), to keep their identities secret. Many people bought the books and wanted to know more about the authors.

Bell brothers

The Brontë sisters published their books under three male names – Acton, Currer, and Ellis Bell, the initials of which matched those of the sisters' own names. To begin with, even their publishers did not know who the "Bell brothers" really were.



Jane Eyre

Charlotte Brontë's first novel tells the story of Jane Eyre and her struggle to be an independent woman in a hostile society. Working as a governess, she falls in love with her employer, Mr Rochester, only to discover terrible secrets in his past. The novel was considered radical in its time.



Wuthering Heights

Emily Brontë's novel follows a series of tragic relationships through different generations and is especially famous for its depiction of Catherine and Heathcliff. Set against the Yorkshire countryside, the novel deals with contemporary issues of social change and industrialization.

Angria and Gondal

To amuse themselves in the bleak moorland rectory, the Brontë children invented two imaginary lands, called Angria and Gondal. They wrote many stories and poems about these lands, which were peopled with heroes and heroines who lived exciting and tragic lives.

CHARLOTTE BRONTË

- 1816 Born Yorkshire, England.
- 1822–32 Educated at Cowan Bridge School and Miss Wooler's School, Roe Head, Yorkshire.
- 1846 Publishes her poems.
- 1847 Publishes *Jane Eyre*.
- 1849 Publishes *Shirley*.
- 1853 Publishes *Villette*.
- 1854 Marries Arthur Nicholls.
- 1855 Dies.

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